Westbrook School Committee

~ School Committee Meeting ~

Date: Wednesday, January 14, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 117 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1154494646
Packet: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1oTQFeFYsw7t3c49ZfJ0LghKA_OCqn099/view (Google Drive, via westbrookschools.org)

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *The full committee (all seven members) plus both student representatives were present. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Superintendent's Report

Halal-Certified School Meals & WRVC Recruiting Video [3:58]

Discussion Summary

School Nutrition Director Mary Emerson reported that Westbrook is among the only U.S. school districts offering halal-certified meals districtwide, and that Westbrook High School was the first school in the nation to achieve certified K-12 halal service. The program, certified by the Islamic Food and Nutrition Council of America (IFANCA) and built with a regional Halal Meals Network (Portland, South Portland, and the Cumberland County Food Security Council), launched at the high school in 2024, expanded to the middle school last spring, and reached all three elementary schools this month. For Ramadan (Feb. 17–Mar. 19, 2026) the high school will offer take-home meals via an after-hours vending machine. Emerson said the program has drawn interest from districts in Washington State, Vermont, and New York.

WRVC Director Gloria Noyes and Assistant Director Kim Bennett presented a new, unscripted student-testimonial recruiting video for the Westbrook Regional Vocational Center (WRVC), spanning early childhood education, electrical, automotive, EMS/firefighting, culinary, and business programs. Recruiting season is underway, with online applications opening February 1. Superintendent Dr. Peter Lancia separately corrected a date in the packet's FY27 budget calendar: the City Council's second budget reading will be May 4, 2026 at 6:00 PM, not April 4 as earlier circulated.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational presentations.

Action Items

None.

Chair / Student / Committee Reports

Subcommittee Assignments, Annual Workshop & Student Report [25:44]

Discussion Summary

Chair Andrea Mancuso announced subcommittee assignments for the year: Finance (Noreen Poitras, Chair; Erin Cavallaro; Allison Brunette), Facilities (Brooke Reed, Chair; Katy Rice), Educational Programs (Katy Rice, Chair; Dr. Flynn Ross), and Policy (Erin Cavallaro, Chair; Andrea Mancuso). The committee's annual orientation workshop with legal counsel is set for January 28 at 6:30 PM. Mancuso also reported a recent joint meeting with the Mayor and city department heads reviewing the school department's capital improvement project submissions, describing it as productive ahead of a forthcoming conversation on shared municipal-school resource funding.

Student Representatives Jamila Mohamed Ahmed and Tina Nguyen reported the high school's Bottles and Cans Club raised $3,600 before winter break, funding $60 Hannaford gift cards for 60 Westbrook families facing food insecurity, plus updates from all three elementary schools (Saccarappa, Congin, Canal) on testing, events, and Canal's newly unveiled mascot, Cosmo Coyote.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational reports.

Action Items

None.

Finance, Policy, Cell Phone Ad Hoc & Educational Programs Updates [34:21]

Discussion Summary

Finance Committee's January meeting was storm-cancelled and rescheduled to January 21; Chair Poitras reminded newer members that budget-review sessions require four members present. Facilities did not meet in December. The Policy Committee (reported by Mancuso) found the district's homework policy outdated and asked the leadership team to revise it; tabled a records-retention policy update pending a staff review; and is preparing a recommendation on Policy KEB (complaints against school personnel) largely adopting Maine School Management Association model language.

The cell-phone ad hoc committee (Cavallaro) surveyed high school students, faculty, and staff in December on cell phone use, gathering baseline data ahead of vendor outreach and planned community forums this winter and spring. Educational Programs (Rice) previewed three items: the district assuming new pre-K programming at Canal School as the state's CDS program ends; an early-stage “intervention programming” framework aimed at more tier-one classroom support; and curriculum changes including a phased return from integrated “SM1/SM2” math to a traditional Algebra 1/Algebra 2/Geometry sequence, a new CTE Exploratory Program for sophomores, a new Cooperative Education credit program, and continued growth in WRVC's cybersecurity program.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational reports.

Action Items

None.

New Business

12.1 & 12.2 — Executive Session (Personnel Matter) & Same-Night Agreement Authorization [45:39]

Discussion Summary

The committee recessed into executive session under 1 M.R.S.A. § 405(6)(A) to discuss a personnel matter, joined by HR Director Martha Sumner and Assistant Superintendent of Operations and Finance Dr. Brian Mazjanis. The content of executive-session discussion is confidential by law and is not reflected in the source video or this summary. Upon returning to open session, the committee amended the agenda to add item 12.2, authorizing the Superintendent to sign an agreement reached in that discussion and carry out its terms, taken up immediately as a combined first-and-final reading.

Key Decisions

✓ Entered executive session: approved 7–0, moved by Chair Mancuso, seconded by Noreen Poitras.

✓ Agenda amendment to add 12.2: approved 7–0, moved by Katy Rice, seconded by Erin Cavallaro.

✓ Item 12.2 (agreement authorization, first and final reading): approved 7–0, moved by Katy Rice, seconded by Erin Cavallaro.

Action Items

None.

Minutes Approval & Floor Correction (Dec. 10 & Dec. 18, 2025) [1:47]

Discussion Summary

Chair Mancuso noted the December 18, 2025 minutes needed a floor amendment to correctly reflect that the committee's executive session that night ended in a 7–0 vote to enter it, and that the committee adjourned directly from executive session without returning to open session.

Key Decisions

✓ Minutes approved as amended, 6–1 with one abstention (member not identified in the transcript).

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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